Officials also goofed up badly on basic protocol by taking the minor sons into custody, and it was only after Shaista went to court that they admitted to it.

The Atiq-Umesh rivalry had been on for the past 18 years. In fact, Umesh was returning from a hearing in a kidnapping case he had filed against Atiq in 2006 when he was shot dead, in a scene quite reminiscent of how Raju Pal was done in back then. A historysheeter like his rivals, Raju was murdered just months after winning the Allahabad (West) assembly seat in 2005, defeating Atiq's younger brother Azim. That case is now with the CBI and charges are being framed against Atiq and Azim. Atiq is currently in Ahmedabad's Sabarmati jail; two of his sons are in jails in UP.

The two incidents sparked a heated debate in the UP assembly on February 25 with CM Adityanath and Samajwadi Party (SP) chief Akhilesh Yadav going hammer and tongs at each other. Yogi accused the SP chief of being in cahoots with the "mafias" and added: "*Unko mitti mein mila denge* (I'll ground them into the dust)…you first welcome the criminals with garlands and then create drama over the law and order situation."

Akhilesh retorted with a question that sought to turn the tables right back on Yogi, "Is this the Ramrajya you promise, where guns are being fired openly? The police is a complete failure and the BJP is responsible." He also referred to the Kanpur Dehat incident where the mother-daughter duo was killed as another manifestation of the government's arrogance and the 'injustice' against the poor in the state.

In Kanpur Dehat's Madauli village, victim Pramila Dixit's son Shivam claims that a district administration team led by the sub-divisional magistrate (SDM) arrived with a bulldozer in tow. "My parents were sleeping inside the house. They demolished it without telling us and set it on fire. I somehow managed to get out. The cops were trying to push me back inside. My father was severely burnt, while my mother and sister died in the fire," he says.

After the incident, the victim's family refused to claim the bodies till the accused are arrested. The burnt bodies lay for several hours in the open ground among protests. Finally, after deputy CM Brajesh Pathak's intervention, the family agreed to the cremation. The Kanpur Dehat police have registered a murder FIR against 39 people, including the SDM, *lekhpal* (revenue officer) and the local police SHO.

PRAMILA DIXIT AND DAUGHTER NEHA WERE BURNT ALIVE IN A "BULLDOZER ACTION" IN KANPUR DEHAT



SHATTERED Pramila Dixit's husband sits in protest among the rubble of their house in Kanpur Dehat

PTI

The Opposition has tried to recast the incident as another instance of atrocities against the Brahmin community, a charge that had pursued Yogi even during his first term. Congress state spokesperson Anshu Awasthi says, "This is not the first incident; earlier also Brahmins were a target under Yogi's raj. Strict action must be taken against the accused." SP MLA Manoj Pandey has also been vocal on "Yogi's bulldozers targeting the Brahmins".

Senior AAP leaders led by party's UP in-charge Sanjay Singh even performed a 'bulldozer ahuti yagya' in Lucknow on the occasion of Mahashivratri. Even a section of the BJP organisation seems to be unhappy with the "free hand" given to the officials; they feel the incident could alienate the Brahmins "who are our core voters".

But, perhaps egged on by Yogi's brazenness, UP's lawmakers are champing at the bit. In the past two weeks, BJP MP from Kannauj Subrat Pathak has publicly commented that he "won't be surprised if gangster Atiq Ahmed's car overturns, just like gangster Vikas Dubey's did", a reference to the way the latter infamously met his end while being escorted back by UP Police from Madhya Pradesh in July 2020. Officials had then said that the car he was travelling in had overturned, and that Dubey was shot dead when he made a run for it. Minister J.P.S. Rathore, too, has made comments along these lines. Atiq has now cited these comments in a petition with the SC seeking its protection where he said he feared for his life.

Besides the perception of lawless officials running amok, the events of the past week do not bode well for Yogi's plan to showcase UP as an investment destination. He is lucky the fire from the Kanpur Dehat incident got doused quickly, but a couple of more incidents like this will put him in the spot. ■